Who Do Dad's Documents Name?

A worksheet for writing down what the papers say, not what the family remembers.

“I think my sister is his power of attorney” is a memory. The name on the signed page is something you can copy down.

Fill this in with the papers in front of you, and with Dad beside you if he'd like to be. Copy names and dates exactly as they're written. If you haven't seen a document, write “haven't seen” and leave it.

The financial power of attorney

The person it names to make financial decisions, any second person named after them, and the date it was signed. Copy the names as they're written on the page.

FOR EXAMPLE Signed the year Dad retired. Names Karen. A second name comes after hers: Uncle Ray.

The healthcare decision-making documents

A healthcare directive, or whatever the page calls itself. Who it names to make healthcare decisions, anyone named after them, and the date.

FOR EXAMPLE Advance healthcare directive, same folder, same date. Names Karen first, then David.

The will and any trust

The date on each, and the people each one names, in whatever role the page gives them. You are copying names, not reading for meaning. If Dad would rather keep the contents to himself, write only the date and where it's kept.

FOR EXAMPLE Will: Dad says it's older than the power of attorney. He'd rather we didn't read it, so we noted the date and the drawer. Trust: not sure there is one. Ask Dad.

What has changed in the family since each was signed

A marriage, a death, a move, a sale. Write the change and roughly when, beside the document's date. Don't decide what it means for the document.

FOR EXAMPLE Since the power of attorney was signed: Uncle Ray moved across the country. Karen married. Dad sold the lake cabin.

What you haven't seen, and what you'd ask an elder law attorney

Anything above that came from memory or from someone else's say-so, and the questions the copying raised. Whether a document still fits is one of them, and it isn't yours to answer.

FOR EXAMPLE Haven't seen the power of attorney itself; only heard that Karen is named. For the attorney: do Dad's existing powers of attorney remain appropriate?

Who filled this in, on what date, and from which papers

What this shows you

Three things: who the papers name, when each was signed, and what has changed in the family since. It doesn't show whether a document is valid, complete or still fits, or who has the legal authority to act. Nothing here adds up to a score or a level. Those questions go to an elder law attorney who knows your state, and nothing on this page is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've copied down who the papers name instead of relying on memory. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about the rest of your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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